

ANGLO-SAXONS AND NORMANS

The term **Anglo-Saxon** is used to refer to the various Germanic tribes who invaded and occupied the British Isles from the mid-5th century CE. They were mainly infantry fighters, armed with spears and short fighting knives (*seaxes*), although their elite troops had elaborate armour and fine pattern-welded swords. Originally a Viking group from Scandinavia, the Normans were established in northern France from 911 CE. They conquered Sicily and parts of southern Italy by the early 11th century, and invaded England in 1066. Their army contained a larger number of mounted warriors than the Anglo-Saxons, and also made effective use of archers.

▲ ANGLO-SAXON SWORD

Date 500–600CE

Origin England

Length 1.05m (3½ft)

Anglo-Saxon swords were designed to inflict cutting blows, most often to the neck – which was usually fatal – or to the leg or sword arm, thus disabling the opponent. Their scabbards were attached to the wearer's belt by a loop.

Typical, slightly tapering double-edged blade

► SUTTON HOO HELMET

Date c.625CE

Origin England

Material Tin, bronze, silver

Found in the royal ship burial at Sutton Hoo in England, this is one of the most elaborate Germanic helmets to have survived. Its cheekpiece, facemask, and neck guard are decorated with tinned bronze foil pieces.

Gilded dragon's head running over cap

Cheekpiece

Thrusting point

▲ LONG SAXON KNIFE

Date 600–1000CE

Origin Northern Europe

Weight 60g (2oz)

Length 24.76cm (9¾in)

The Saxon *seax*, a single-bladed knife, was as much a domestic implement as a weapon of war. A piece of wood or bone would have been attached to the tang to form a grip, but does not survive in this example.

▲ SHORT SAXON KNIFE

Date 600–1000CE

Origin Northern Europe

Weight 60g (2oz)

Length 19cm (7½in)

Most Saxon fighting knives, or *seaxes*, were made by twisting and hammer-welding hot bars of iron and steel – a process called pattern-welding – to produce a sharp, durable blade.

▲ LONG SAXON SPEAR

Date 400–500CE

Origin Northern Europe

Length 48cm (19in)

The spear was the Anglo-Saxon warrior's primary weapon. Many had long, leaf-shaped blades and wooden shafts traditionally made from ash. The warriors used the spears mainly with one hand, while holding a shield with the other.

Iron rings interlinked to form mail

► ANGLO-SAXON MAIL

Date 10th century CE

Origin England

Weight 23kg (50¾lb)

Length 90cm (35½in)

Full suits of Anglo-Saxon mail do not survive, but they could comprise up to 20,000 interlinked 8mm (0.3in) iron rings. They were extremely effective in protecting against cutting blows from swords or axes, but less so against sword thrusts. The item pictured here is a modern replica.